From the Depths of Space

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"Humanitarian" Management

COL-310700

"Humanitarian" Management

Ward, Rehab Center

The alarm indicators on various monitoring devices flash steadily.

On the hospital bed, the rescued individual's breathing maintains a steady rhythm. He's still lost in a deep sleep.

Ulrich: Is he still in danger?

Hofmann: Not for now. Adler's vitals have stabilized.

Ulrich: It's a miracle. I've never heard of anyone surviving a fall from the sixth floor of a building.

Hofmann: He didn't fall six floors. The railings in the Laplace corridor stopped him.

The investigator is meticulous. She won't allow such an exaggerated claim to be thrown out without rebuttal.

Hofmann: What he did do is consume expired food and an excessive amount of alcohol, resulting in simultaneous food and alcohol poisoning.

Ulrich: Whether in mind or body, humans seem far too fragile in the face of the "Storm."

He stops himself from speaking further, realizing a little too late how inappropriate his comment is.

Hofmann: You aren't wrong.

Fortunately, the patient's sister agrees.

Hofmann: I'll help him quit drinking, but I can't say how long it will take for him to accept the new reality.

Hofmann: I'll let him know you came by when he wakes up.

Ulrich: Would you also let him know why I came by?

He proceeds to formally state the purpose of his visit.

Ulrich: The LSCC has a backlog of encrypted internal research data, and most of the personnel who originally held the passwords and biometric verification information have already been reversed.

Ulrich: Madam Lucy is gathering capable researchers to work on decrypting the files, and I came to confirm whether Adler would be fit for the task in his current condition.

Hofmann: No. I'm afraid he's not fit to return to work at the moment. He still needs time to recover.

Hofmann: I'll try to persuade him to join the cryptography team once he's recovered. But I'm just his sister. He doesn't exactly listen to me all the time.

Ulrich: Thank you for providing me with this information.

Ulrich carefully crosses off an item from his to-do list.

Ulrich: As you wish, I'll give you some privacy, Ms. Hofmann.

Hofmann: Go ahead.

Ulrich quickly leaves the ward.

Corridor, Laplace

The cryptography team's newest assistant meets Ulrich in the corridor and hands a printed document to him.

Research Assistant: Here's the Monthly Important File Cryptography Report.

Ulrich: Thank you, Dora. Also—

He slips another list from the folder and thrusts it at her.

Ulrich: I found some new encrypted files in Owen's office yesterday. Some of them have already been added to this week's to-do list.

Ulrich: Please sync this up with the other members of the cryptography team on your way back.

Research Assistant: Oh, my ...

Disbelief wells up behind her goggles, but, like an arrow to armor, her feelings deflect straight off the cryptography lead's helmet.

Research Assistant: I must remind you, Lead, that the team is already at their maximum workload.

Ulrich: I've accounted for the additional work hours required from each member. It amounts to no more than 80 minutes per person per day.

Research Assistant: Sir, this workload has begun to seriously interfere with our time off.

Research Assistant: I won't be able to attend my weekly Cleanup for Mental Clarity session!

Ulrich: Not this again. You have a PhD and two master's degrees. You shouldn't be wasting your time cleaning windows.

A flurry of rebuttals swirls in Dora's mind, but she knows that such things can't be solved through direct communication.

Research Assistant: I ... I'm afraid I must bring this issue up with Madam Lucy!

Ulrich: You're overreacting, Dora.

Research Assistant: I stand by my rights.

Ulrich feels a sharp, painful electric current course through him.

Ulrich: Fine! I'll report on the team's workload to Madam Lucy right away and submit your complaint on your behalf.

Research Assistant: Thank you, Lead.

Finding no issue with having the subject of her complaint deliver it for her, Dora leaves feeling relieved.

Director's Office, Laplace

Despite Ulrich's unrest, the work report must be carried out in an orderly manner.

Ulrich: In summary, the progress on processing the remaining encrypted data has reached 103.15% this month, slightly exceeding expectations.

Lucy: I am pleased. It is perfectly in line with theoretical projections.

For a machine, "in line with theoretical projections" is high praise indeed.

Lucy: Any other news to report?

Ulrich lets out a heavy, windless sigh.

Ulrich: There is one thing. The cryptography team assistant, Dora, has filed a complaint against me. She believes the current work arrangements greatly exceed reasonable standards.

Lucy nods.

Lucy: The complaint is justified. The cryptography team has been operating beyond "humanitarian" management standards for some time.

Ulrich momentarily struggles to grasp such a term.

Ulrich: "Humanitarian" management?

Lucy: Your confusion is understandable. This is, in fact, the first time I am putting this concept into practice.

Lucy: Based on my analysis of the operating procedures and current human resource situation at Laplace, I plan to implement a "humanitarian" management model.

Ulrich: How should I understand the strategies of this new model?

Lucy: Perhaps an example would better illustrate it. For instance, would you like to apply for an extended leave from headquarters, Ulrich?

Ulrich: What?

The abruptness of this question leaves him dumbfounded.

Ulrich: I'm sorry. I don't understand what you mean.

It's quite difficult to conduct a conversation on "humanitarian" management between two parties, neither of which are humans to begin with.

Lucy: Returning to the complaint. Aside from the one you submitted yourself, I have received 27 similar complaints in the last week.

Lucy: Many of the letters came from your team members, and they all share a similar theme.

Lucy: "The cryptography lead has failed to adequately consider the physiological needs of his organic colleagues."

Almost 30 complaints in one week. Ulrich anxiously ponders his response.

Ulrich: I can reduce the working hours of my organic colleagues, but I can't adjust everyone's schedule to match the slowest member.

Lucy: I recommend ensuring everyone gets the eight hours of sleep necessary to maintain good health. This does not mean, however, that the remaining 16 hours should all be used for work.

Ulrich: I'll revise the work schedule according to your recommendations, Madam Lucy.

The slit in Lucy's face flashes in approval.

Lucy: Now, on the matter of leave.

Lucy: I believe a proper and sufficient vacation will help you and your team relieve yourselves of excessive stress.

Lucy: You must understand, this is a critical element in implementing "humanitarian" management.

Ulrich: But what about the rest of the encrypted files?

Lucy: You have successfully built a team capable of handling routine cryptography tasks independently. That deserves recognition, Ulrich.

He raises one last concern.

Ulrich: The next "Storm" could occur at any time. Locations outside headquarters are unsafe.

Lucy: Your concern has been fully noted and considered. I can recommend a safe location for you—the LSCC's Plesetsk branch.

Lucy: According to our records, the geographical location of this branch has granted it the same immunity to the "Storm" as headquarters.

Lucy: Not long ago, Ludwig assumed leadership there at my suggestion.

Lucy: He mentioned that a set of facilities has been established specifically as a safe retreat for the recuperation of staff members.

A familiar name.

Ulrich: Ludwig ... So he was transferred all the way to Plesetsk, was he?

Lucy: The decision to send you there has been made in consideration of mutual interests. I am sure he will understand.

Ulrich: Yes, Madam Lucy.

The Awakened finally surrenders under the banner of "humanitarian" management.

Ulrich: Fine, I'm taking a break.

Lucy: Very well. This will be a solid first step in the implementation of "humanitarian" management.

Satisfied with her successful persuasion, Lucy continues.

Lucy: Good news. I have reviewed your work hour records, and your accumulated vacation time has reached 999 days.

Lucy: In fact, the actual number may be greater, as early spreadsheets only allowed for a three-digit maximum.

Lucy: Until then, I will leave it to you to decide when you return. Enjoy your vacation, Ulrich.

A New Friend

COL-310701

A New Friend

Thanks to jet engines and Bernoulli's principle, the distant journey doesn't take long to cover.

Corridor, Branch Care Center

The Plesetsk branch bears a striking resemblance to headquarters, a result of the rigorous standardization of the branch design guidelines set out by Laplace. Ulrich almost feels like he's in a dream.

Ulrich: This place looks almost identical to headquarters.

His admiration piques the host's interest.

Branch Receptionist: Yes, but unlike headquarters, we have more space, less work, and lower outdoor temperatures. It's a perfect holiday spot.

Branch Receptionist: Welcome to Plesetsk Retreat Center, Ulrich! Come, let me show you around the facilities.

Ulrich: Actually, I need a lab to store my data.

The receptionist lets out a stifled hum as he tries to grasp these words.

Branch Receptionist: Data? Do you mean you brought work here? Aren't you on holiday?

Ulrich: I have to do something while I'm here.

It is clear that he is already regretting this "holiday."

Branch Receptionist: That won't do. Holidays are for disconnecting from work, not taking on new projects. You have to understand that people work to live, not the other way around.

He pats Ulrich's steel frame with unwarranted familiarity.

Branch Receptionist: Play some games, sleep in, maybe have a chat with the others here; if you're lucky, they'll even be willing to hang out with you—that's what people do on a holiday.

Branch Receptionist: Besides, your room hasn't been cleaned yet.

This holiday checklist utterly fails to spark Ulrich's interest.

Ulrich: I'll clean the room myself.

Branch Receptionist: Alright then. Follow me, my serious friend.

The receptionist leads Ulrich down the corridor and to the door of his room.

Office, Branch Care Center

Ulrich: ...?!

As the door opens, they are hit with a heady stench. Ulrich immediately shuts off his olfactory input channel.

Branch Receptionist: Here we are, Ulrich.

Ulrich: It seems like a dumpster exploded in here! Doesn't the Plesetsk management protocol include regular cleaning of vacant rooms?

Branch Receptionist: Actually, it doesn't.

Ulrich: ...

Branch Receptionist: It'll be best if you don't set your expectations too high, Ulrich. This was originally an abandoned administrative facility, remember.

Branch Receptionist: After Mr. Ludwig repurposed it into a recovery center, management was deliberately reduced to avoid disturbing the occupants.

Ulrich: I can handle the cleaning myself. But I need a high-performance computer that meets laboratory standards.

Branch Receptionist: Uh, but you're not on any projects right now. So, it's unlikely they'll give you anything close to a high-performance computer during your stay here.

A spark flares from one of UIrich's circuits.

Ulrich: I'll submit my request, regardless of the outcome.

With that, he steps determinedly into the garbage dump of a room and starts picking trash off the floor.

Ulrich: A snack shopping list, a custom party light microcontroller ...

Ulrich: A pile of bizarre ergonomic keyboards, broken electronic music synthesizers ... all of it should go to the warehouse. And this—

Ulrich reaches for a small device on top of the storage cabinet.

An alarm pierces the room like a panicked scream.

Ulrich: ...?!

Ulrich: What is this?

Branch Receptionist: I have no idea. Maybe a homemade circuit testing device?

Ulrich: No, the craftsmanship is much too precise, and the components are custom-made. This is clearly a sophisticated instrument. Certainly not something that should be left unattended in a pile of junk.

Ulrich: Could you check for any transfer records?

Branch Receptionist: Just so you know, Ulrich, with the "Storms" coming back like this, things have been falling by the wayside.

Branch Receptionist: No one knows how many things we've misplaced over the years. How could we possibly trace where something you found in a pile of junk came from?

Ulrich: All this work on systems and procedures, yet when you actually need to use the information from any of them, they're totally useless.

The receptionist nudges Ulrich gently with his elbow.

Branch Receptionist: Don't overthink it. Just toss the thing.

As if resisting its fate of being discarded into storage, the device blares its alarm once more.

Branch Receptionist: What now?

Ulrich: Did I trigger a switch? No, wait.

Ulrich: It seems to be responding to our conversation. And the first time it sounded was when I accidentally touched it.

Branch Receptionist: You don't think ...?

Ulrich: And these ripples on the screen ... While I can't decipher their meaning, they may be conveying some sort of message.

Ulrich: Could it be ...

Realizing a critical possibility, Ulrich carefully places the oscilloscope back in its original position.

Ulrich: It's an Awakened coming to life all alone in a deserted office! You—

He turns around only to find that the receptionist is long gone.

Ulrich: Fine, I'll handle this myself.

Left without assistance, Ulrich faces the dual challenge of social interaction and technical problem-solving alone.

Straightening both his attire and his back, he adopts a formal, courteous tone.

Ulrich: Hello?

[English text unavailable]

COL-310702

Office, Branch Care Center

He gives one last wave to the oscilloscope, only to receive a series of erratic, indecipherable waveforms in return.

It seems that it has not yet managed to find a way to express "hello."

Ulrich: Perhaps awakening alone in an abandoned office has caused its language functionality to deteriorate?

Oscilloscope: Beep.

The oscilloscope responds—or at least seems to.

Ulrich: Oh, I didn't mean to belittle you ...

The display's waveform flattens into a straight line as the device shuts down completely.

Ulrich: I suppose I deserve that.

Before Ulrich can sink too deeply into self-pity, the receptionist reappears.

Branch Receptionist: Ulrich, stop what you're doing.

Branch Receptionist: The welcome party's about to begin!

Ulrich: Welcome party?

A Welcome Party

COL-310703

A Welcome Party

Ulrich is ushered into a laboratory packed with computers.

The thick smell of alcohol and an explosion of cheers fill the air.

Idle Laboratory, Branch Care Center

Branch Receptionist: Let's raise a toast!

Branch Receptionist: A big welcome to our distinguished researcher from headquarters—Ulrich!

Ulrich: Is this really the ... banquet hall?

The floor and workbenches are laden with smoked fish, slices of red sausage, and unmarked bottles of vodka, all sourced from nearby towns.

Branch Receptionist: That's right. It's a reasonable use of public facilities, don't you think?

Ulrich: Hardly! What kind of place is this for a party? Any spilled alcohol could corrode and short-circuit the equipment.

Branch Receptionist: Yes, but geometrically speaking, it's the central point of the facility. It's the closest place to everyone's rooms.

He extends a finger and traces dazzling geometric patterns in the air.

Branch Receptionist: We've hosted a number of parties in this facility. Both experience and theory confirm that this lab is the most popular location.

The eccentric logic of Laplace's scientists extends even to this remote branch near the Arctic Circle.

Ulrich: I don't think this is a math problem. It's a systemic issue.

Ulrich: Dining in the lab should be strictly prohibited. The equipment we have left is already dwindling; we can't afford to lose any more.

Branch Researcher I: Don't be such a buzzkill, Ulrich. This is your welcome party!

Branch Researcher II: That's right! We always welcome the newcomers!

Branch Receptionist: I'm Dmitry, that's Alexander, and over there is Elena ... Oh, and there's Ivan, too, but he hasn't shown up yet.

Dmitry: No use waiting for him. Let's have a drink!

He holds out a glass of vodka spiked with chili peppers.

Dmitry: Come on, friend!

Ulrich shuts off his olfactory function.

Ulrich: No, I refuse to drink alcohol. Don't you have anything non-alcoholic?

This question is met with a burst of laughter akin to the howling winds of Siberia.

Dmitry gives Ulrich an overly enthusiastic pat on the tank.

Dmitry: Only vodka can help people forget their troubles, my friend. Give it a try. It might work for you, too.

Dmitry raises his glass, leading the group in another round, but Ulrich still doesn't touch the glass in front of him.

Ulrich: I never asked for a welcome party. Were these supplies purchased with the LSCC's budget?

Dmitry answers his question without hesitation.

Dmitry: "To Branch Leader Ludwig: In order to host Team Leader Ulrich, alcohol and food have been purchased as follows. Please approve for reimbursement."

Dmitry: That's it.

Ulrich: It all reeks of corruption!

Ulrich: The LSCC's funds should go toward researching the "Storm," not unnecessary indulgences.

The party comes to an abrupt halt.

Dmitry: What? This isn't unnecessary at all.

Dmitry: That better just be a bad joke.

Ulrich: I'm not joking.

Branch Researcher I: Oh, dear! You're serious?

Branch Researcher II: Here is the case. We just wanted to lighten your mood, Ulrich.

Branch Researcher I: What a buzzkill.

Ulrich: But I can't—

A wave of shushing drowns out Ulrich's protests.

Even the densest person could feel the shift in this room's mood.

Ulrich: I've had enough. Enjoy your vodka and smoked fish. I refuse to participate in such a misuse of funds.

Ulrich turns toward the door. The researchers quickly clear a path.

Their eyes following him as he swiftly exits the room.

Peripheries, Branch Care Center

Ulrich feels as though he's just knocked over a beaker full of liquid and spilled dangerous chemicals all over the floor.

Though harmless to him, the mess leaves him irritated.

Ulrich: ...

Facing the snow-covered plain, he aimlessly watches the various black dots scattered in the distance.

One of them starts to move closer, slowly taking the shape of a person as it approaches.

Ulrich: ...?

A distant voice drifts over, carried by the cold wind.

???: Hey—! Ulrich—? Is that you—?

First, he notices a long coat; then, a head of silver-white hair, just like the snow.

Ulrich: Windsong!?

Soon, the figure is close enough to engage in conversation.

This is an unexpected meeting for them both.

Windsong: Yes, it's me. What brings you to Plesetsk?

Ulrich: I'm on holiday. Are you?

Windsong: No, I'm working in a nearby mine. I just come back every now and then to restock supplies.

Ulrich: This is a serious oversight. I should've visited you at the mine before I came to the recovery center.

Windsong: Forget about it. There's no need for formalities, Ulrich.

Ulrich: Formalities?

He clearly didn't intend it that way.

Ulrich: What I meant was, if I'd visited you first, you might've warned me about how unpleasant the traditions are here.

Windsong: ...

She gives Ulrich a scrutinizing look, like a scholar studying a rare mineral.

Then, after a moment's thought, she comes to a conclusion.

Windsong: Haha.

Her sudden chuckle leaves Ulrich baffled.

Ulrich: ...? What are you laughing at?

Windsong: I see. They must've put you through hell with that whole welcome party.

Windsong: Did you run out on your own, or did they kick you out?

She shakes her head in resignation.

Windsong: No need to answer. It's the same result either way.

Ulrich: Indeed. Couldn't be worse.

Ulrich: They called it a "banquet," but it felt more like an excuse to drink to me.

Windsong: Culturally speaking, for this lot, "banquets" and "drinking" aren't all that different.

Ulrich isn't swayed by such rhetorical dodging.

Ulrich: But we're Laplace researchers. It's our foremost responsibility to focus on theories, ideas, possibilities, and experimentation—that's where we must focus our time.

Ulrich: But now, their minds are filled with nothing but alcohol.

Windsong: They're just trying to relax. That's what vacations are for.

Ulrich: That's not how I see it.

Ulrich: Before coming to Plesetsk, I read the schedules of some mountain sanatoriums. They included activities like resting, gentle walks, and book discussions.

Ulrich: Not one of them recommended consuming alcohol or high-sodium foods. Endless indulgence and escapism help no one.

Windsong: ...

She remains silent for a moment, long enough for the cold wind to suppress Ulrich's internal irritation.

Windsong: Yes. You're right. Giving up isn't the way to face disaster.

Windsong: But it isn't "endless," as you say. It's not necessarily a bad thing to indulge yourself every once in a while.

Ulrich: ...?

Ulrich can't grasp how removing the word "endless" would significantly improve the implications of "indulgence" and "escapism."

Windsong: I know some of the people vacationing here. Most of them were either top students at prestigious institutions or outstanding professionals in their fields.

Windsong: In the past, they buried themselves in libraries and labs, living disciplined lives in pursuit of academia.

Windsong: But the "Storm" turned them into lost souls, unable to hold onto their beliefs or face the new reality.

Windsong: A complete breakdown of order may be just what they need to vent their fears. Then perhaps they will be ready to stand tall once more.

Ulrich: I'm not convinced. Does this psychological therapy method have a solid theoretical foundation?

Windsong shrugs.

Windsong: I guess it's more of an empirical approach.

Windsong: It doesn't deteriorate the diligence, rationality, and sense of responsibility of researchers. In fact, they usually come back with a vengeance.

Ulrich: But personal experience is unreliable. There's no guarantee this method will produce results.

Windsong lets out a soft, bitter laugh.

Windsong: We won't always get the results we hope for. Yet, proving a theory wrong can be just as important as proving one right.

Her gaze shifts past Ulrich's shoulder to the building behind him.

Windsong: So, are you going back, or are you going to stay out here in the cold?

Ulrich: Go on ahead. I'd prefer to stay here until all this nonsense is finished.

Unwanted Noise

COL-310704

Unwanted Noise

Under the Stars

Nightfall comes early.

Windsong already left about an hour ago.

Ulrich: The welcome party should be over by now.

Before the cool air can stiffen his joints, Ulrich heads back inside.

Corridor, Branch Care Center

The banquet venue lies directly on Ulrich's path to the office, forcing him to pass by the geometric center point.

The raucous noise from behind the closed doors suggests the party is still at its peak. Evidently, the guests' excitement doesn't hinge on the presence of the party's guest of honor.

Ulrich: Endless nonsense.

He quickens his pace.

Office, Branch Care Center

The room is still a mess, and Ulrich isn't about to start cleaning it now.

The oscilloscope remains in its original place.

Ulrich: Alright, now we've got time to talk.

Ulrich: Can you turn yourself on?

Despite its connection to a power source, the oscilloscope remains unresponsive.

Ulrich has no choice but to turn it on himself.

Ulrich: The power switch wouldn't be placed among all these tiny buttons. Let's rule out this section.

Ulrich: And it probably isn't on the front panel, so—

Carefully feeling along the back of the machine, he finally finds a toggle switch.

Ulrich: Success.

[English text unavailable]

COL-310705

Office, Branch Care Center

Branch Researcher I: A festive time, with friends aplenty. ♪

Branch Researcher II: We talk of friendship, and days gone by. ♫

Ulrich: This is insane!

Ulrich's train of thought is utterly derailed.

Ulrich: That's enough!

All Researchers: Everyone, raise your glasses!! ♪

Clearly, no amount of shouting from the other side of the door will stop these partiers.

Ulrich: Stop it already!

Corridor, Branch Care Center

By the time Ulrich has stepped into the corridor, all but one of the partiers have already disappeared.

Dmitry: Ulrich, I thought you weren't coming back!

Dmitry: Come—*hic*—join us! We're catching critters. Though, the little tykes seem to have vanished. I-I need a better vantage point.

Dmitry staggers over to the corridor railing and leans most of his body over the edge.

Ulrich lunges forward, grabbing his shirt and yanking him back.

Dmitry: Ow!

Dmitry: W-What was that for?! Ah!! My Carbuncle! My sausages!!

Dmitry: Damn you, Ulrich! This is all your fault!

Ulrich: For flux's sake! I saved your life, you drunken idiot!

Dmitry: *hic* Well, I didn't ask you to save me.

Even Ulrich could tell that Dmitry was mocking his tone from the welcome party.

Ulrich: Unbelievable. This is a research facility, not your tavern.

Ulrich: The next "Storm" could strike at any moment, and here you are wasting away the time drinking!

Dmitry: And what great—*hic*—world-changing research are you working on, Ulrich?

Dmitry: Lead us, O brave Emperor Ulrich! My liege! Lead us to invent the ultimate machine to weather the "Storm"!

Branch Researcher I: Huh? Is someone fighting!?

The commotion in the corridor has caught the attention of a few partiers.

Branch Researcher II: Great! It'd be a waste of this buzz without a good fight to watch.

Branch Researcher I: Heheh. It's Ulrich! Oh, this is way more fun than chasing a Carbuncle.

A growing crowd surrounds Ulrich and Dmitry as their argument continues.

Ulrich: Understanding the "Storm" will require extensive theoretical work and many experiments, yes, but it is by no means an unsolvable global disaster.

Dmitry: Experiments—what, like that piece of electronic junk you picked out from the trash?!

Branch Researcher I: Junk? What junk, Dmitry? Be specific!

Dmitry: An oscilloscope, it was left in the office, and Ulrich thinks it's alive!

The crowd bursts into laughter.

Ulrich: You can't jump to conclusions.

Dmitry: If you want to be a clown so badly, why don't you head over to the circus in Mirny and hand them your resume?

Dmitry: Now that I think about it, your bulbous head would look perfect with a big red nose stuck in the middle.

Branch Researcher I: Haha. Good lord, that's perfect!

Branch Researcher II: That's right, and the circus should still be in town. You'd be just in time.

Ulrich: ENOUGH!

His shout cuts through the mockery like a knife.

Ulrich: I have attempted to communicate with you in a normal, reasonable way.

Ulrich: Now I see that was a huge mistake.

Dmitry: Huh?

Ulrich: Just when I thought perhaps my fellow Laplace researchers might be able to take their responsibilities seriously and not behave like imbeciles, you go and prove me wrong!

Dmitry: I—

Ulrich: Shut it!

Ulrich: The world would be better off if the "Storm" took you all!

Branch Researcher I: ...

Branch Researcher II: ...

Dmitry: ...

Dmitry: Are you serious, Ulrich?

Ulrich says nothing, turns around, and locks himself in his room.

Branch Researcher I: Did I hear that right?

Branch Researcher II: That's too far. What gives him the right to say that?!

Dmitry: Leave him to his tantrums. Let's go.

Dmitry: He'll never be one of us.

No More Idleness

COL-310706

No More Idleness

Office, Branch Care Center

Months pass. Or, is it years?

Aside from moving to a larger, cleaner room, Ulrich's time at Plesetsk hasn't changed much.

The long-abandoned oscilloscope has been placed in the new room. It sits next to a lukewarm cup of coffee.

Ulrich: ...

He deftly presses a couple of buttons and twists a few knobs.

Ulrich: What's on your mind today?

Oscilloscope: Beep—beep-beep beep.

Ulrich has now mastered the external controls of the oscilloscope.

He has never once considered opening the casing to examine its internal structure.

Ulrich: There's no new information. All I can do is replay historical data.

Ulrich: I've already compiled all the recurring patterns from the waveforms. All that's left are a few incomprehensible fragments.

Ulrich: I think I'll need a larger sample size if I'm ever to decode them.

He picks up a well-worn transcript from the desk—notes from a lecture on linguistics by Branch Leader Ludwig.

Some parts of the lecture seem to point him in the right direction to deciphering the oscilloscope's signals, or perhaps they point to somewhere else entirely.

Transcript: "Linguistic rules, including grammar and lexical-concept mapping patterns, are largely established through social consensus, commonly known as 'convention' ..."

Transcript: "Chaos and randomness are fundamental characteristics of natural language. Likewise, language is inherently narrow and biased ..."

Transcript: "This means that the utility of language is limited by the cognitive level of its users ..."

Ulrich: Patterns and chaos coexist. The oscilloscope's signal patterns match the linguistic traits Ludwig described.

Ulrich: Past experiments have also proven that the oscilloscope doesn't react to environmental variables.

Memories of his past experiments bubble up in his mind. Memories of carrying the oscilloscope around the facility and enduring the stares of others as if he were an alien.

Ulrich: Which proves it isn't some kind of monitoring device. No, it's definitely actively transmitting information.

Ulrich: But with the current sample variety, I can't verify my hypothesis any further.

knock-knock

There is a knock on the door.

Windsong: Hey, old friend, are you in there?

For a scholar often out in the field, her visit is unusual.

Ulrich: Windsong? Come in.

She steps in and places some cheese and caviar on the desk.

Ulrich: Thank you, but I have no use for these.

Windsong: Alright, then I'll give them to someone who does.

She promptly takes the gifts back.

Windsong: Any progress with the oscilloscope?

Ulrich: Nothing substantial.

Ulrich: Are you here to take a break?

A flicker of surprise crosses Windsong's eyes.

Windsong: No. The "Storm" is coming. I'm here to take shelter. You should've received the alert by now, too.

Ulrich seems to take a long moment to process the urgency of this global disaster.

Ulrich: Oh ... Yes ... of course.

He sinks into a somber mood once again.

Windsong: Hey, Ulrich!

Ulrich: ...?!

Windsong: Why are you just sitting there in silence? What are you thinking about?

Windsong: In less than twelve hours, the outside world will be reversed. Is there anything in this era you've left undone?

Ulrich remains silent, unsure of how to respond.

Oscilloscope: Beep-beep—beep ... beep ...

Windsong: And after the "Storm"? Are you planning to end your vacation and return to headquarters?

Oscilloscope: Beep—beep-beep—

Ulrich: This thing is so noisy.

He reaches out to turn off the oscilloscope, but Windsong stops him.

Windsong: Leave it on. It'll be too quiet here without it.

Windsong: I've had to wrap up my expeditions in the Arctic Circle. After this "Storm" passes, I'll head back to headquarters.

Windsong: I need to organize the data I've collected and give a Ley Lines lecture there.

Windsong: If you're planning to leave, we could head there together.

Ulrich: I haven't decided yet.

Ulrich: Perhaps I've grown accustomed to this undisturbed life. The peace and quiet help me reflect on the era and the "Storm."

Windsong: "Peace and quiet"? You didn't even realize the next "Storm" was already on its way.

Windsong lets out a playful whistle.

Windsong: Not looking too good, my friend. Your long vacation has taken its toll on you.

Windsong: You should return to headquarters, do some real work, and get back into shape, and don't forget to bring some reunion gifts for your team members.

Oscilloscope: Beep ... beep ... beep ... beep ...

Windsong: You agree with me, don't you, little guy?

Surprisingly, the oscilloscope responds even more emphatically to her words.

Oscilloscope: Beep! Beep! Beep!

Ulrich: ...!

Windsong: Wha- ... what?

Ulrich buries his head in the display, the little ball of ferrofluid trembling with the frequency of the signals.

Ulrich: This frequency ... It isn't right.

He grabs his notes from the desk and quickly scans his records.

Ulrich: February's records, no, October's. Here it is, but it doesn't match at all.

Windsong reflexively pulls out a pencil and notebook, only to realize she has nothing to write down.

Windsong: Did you find something?

Ulrich: The amplitude of all the signals is increasing. The peaks and troughs of the new waveforms are nearly maxing out the instrument's display.

Windsong: Has the regularity been disrupted?

Ulrich: Indeed. The probability of a familiar pattern appearing has dropped significantly. The randomness of the waveforms is rapidly increasing.

Windsong: Could it really be reacting to what we're saying? No!

Windsong: There's no reason it should respond to what we say, and you know I've never believed this thing is an Awakened.

Ulrich: Even I've almost given up on that hypothesis.

Windsong: That's a relief. Then, what exactly is going on right now?

Windsong: Has something changed?

The ferrofluid shoots upright, forming an exclamation mark.

Ulrich: It's the "Storm." It's directly affecting it!

Ulrich: Our holiday is over.

"Humanitarian" Approach

COL-310707

"Humanitarian" Approach

Cryptography Room, Laplace

It's an ordinary workday like any other.

Research Assistant: *humming* ♪♪♪

Dora hums a cheerful tune as she dusts the equipment with a handheld static duster.

Research Assistant: *humming* ♪♪♪

Without warning, the lab door opens.

Research Assistant: ...?

Ulrich: Dora, what are you doing?

A long-absent figure appears in the doorway.

Research Assistant: U-Ulrich?

She hastily flings the duster to the workbench beside her.

Ulrich: I thought you'd know better than to throw things onto the workbench by now.

Research Assistant: I'm just ... a little surprised.

Ulrich: Fair enough. But still, take care of the equipment. These integrated circuit machines just keep getting more expensive.

Ulrich briefly steps out before returning with a heavy piece of computing equipment.

Research Assistant: What's this?

Ulrich: A gaming console for the team. It comes preloaded with Ping Pong League, Super Spaceman, and Leviathan and the Deep Sea Maze.

Ulrich: It can also serve as a versatile development platform. You can design your own games on it.

Research Assistant: So, what's it doing here?

The image before her is almost surreal.

Ulrich: It's a gift. I bought it for the team.

Before Dora can react, Ulrich has turned and left once again.

He quickly returns, this time carrying a smaller device—the oscilloscope.

He carefully places it on the workbench.

Ulrich: I have to admit, taking such a long holiday was an irresponsible act of negligence on my part.

Research Assistant: No, Lead, I think—

Ulrich: I'd like to apologize for my absence. There's no excuse for spending so much time at the retreat center and neglecting my work here.

Research Assistant: It's ... it's fine!

Ulrich: I've already submitted a request to Madam Lucy. For the next 36 months, I will forfeit all personal salary and benefits.

Research Assistant: I knew it. Don't tell me—

Ulrich: And I'll compensate for the loss caused by my absence by doubling the work hours.

Research Assistant: NOOO!!

Ulrich seems deaf to Dora's protests, moving straight to the point.

He plugs the oscilloscope in and turns it on.

Ulrich: From now on, the cryptography team will take on a new long-term task.

Ulrich: I require each team member to independently propose a framework for classifying the waveforms from this oscilloscope without discussing it with each other.

Ulrich: This secrecy is paramount in covering any blind spots in my methods.

Research Assistant: But I haven't been briefed on anything.

Ulrich: No need. Get to work right away. I'll show you how it's done.

[English text unavailable]

COL-310708

Cryptography Room, Laplace

The work on the oscilloscope quickly becomes a part of the team's routine daily tasks.

Unfortunately, today's research still yields no progress.

Research Assistant: Would you like to hear my thoughts on the oscilloscope, sir?

Ulrich: Go ahead.

Research Assistant: Maybe it really is just a broken machine, like most of the equipment we've cleared out and stored in the repair room.

Ulrich: But the "Storm" noticeably impacted the readings. That's highly unusual.

Research Assistant: No, it's actually quite ordinary.

Research Assistant: The "Storm" interferes with all arcane phenomena. Clearly, arcane technology was involved in building this instrument.

Research Assistant: Of course, it's connected to the "Storm." Almost everything is.

This answer does little to satisfy Ulrich.

Ulrich: So you're saying it isn't unique?

Research Assistant: Precisely.

Ulrich: We need more evidence before we can come to that conclusion.

Research Assistant: But the uniqueness you suggest isn't supported by any current evidence.

Before any rebuttal can come, she continues.

Research Assistant: You plan to establish different array systems to correlate changes between information patterns.

Research Assistant: But this method won't eliminate all errors. We'll be forced to acknowledge the inherent chaos of this system.

Research Assistant: We could spend immense computational power exploring every possibility for half a century and still end up with nothing.

Ulrich's silence suggests he has already considered these issues.

Ulrich: We could request more resources to address the problems you mentioned.

Research Assistant: That would require submitting a dedicated research project application, including a preliminary evaluation of personnel, funding, and equipment.

Research Assistant: It won't be easy to justify the research value, and we can't just turn the whole cryptography team into an oscilloscope cryptography unit.

Research Assistant: Where would you find people with the necessary time and expertise to join the project?

Research Assistant: Wait!

Even she seems surprised by her sudden bout of inspiration.

Research Assistant: I know just the person!

Corridor, Laplace

Dora strides purposefully down the corridor, like a deer charging through the forest.

Ulrich jogs behind her.

Research Assistant: Huff ... huff ...

She comes to a stop in front of a closed door.

Just as she's about to ring the bell, Ulrich intercepts her.

Ulrich: A word of warning, Dora. Enigma has been a recluse for years. Any attempts to communicate with him won't end well.

Research Assistant: Come on. He deserves a chance, just like anyone else.

Research Assistant: I've dealt with worse characters, you know, those awful old math professors who take pleasure in insulting students.

Research Assistant: I've picked up a few tricks; don't you worry.

She takes a few deep breaths to slow her racing heart.

When she speaks again, her tone is entirely different—like someone trying to persuade a child to do something.

Research Assistant: What's this? *gasp* New puzzle games! Wanna give it a try, Adler?

Ulrich: This is absurd.

She coughs before switching to a more formal tone.

Research Assistant: We're facing a serious problem that requires your expertise, Mr. Adler. I trust it falls within your responsibilities to assist us with this matter.

Ulrich: He'll only laugh in the face of such a fabrication.

Her tone shifts again, this time sounding like a restaurant server.

Research Assistant: Mr. Adler, a messy room isn't doing your mental state any good! Let our Cleanup for Mental Clarity group give you a hand!

Ulrich: That one doesn't even have any work-related information.

Finally, her tone becomes exasperated.

Research Assistant: So, what's YOUR brilliant idea then?!

Ulrich: We shouldn't focus on how to communicate. No, we should focus on how to complete the task with as little communication as possible.

Ulrich: Why don't you organize the materials, open the door, drop the documents on the floor, and leave? Then you can check back later to see if there's any progress.

Research Assistant: ...

Research Assistant: What a convincing solution.

Ulrich: Then we're in agreement.

Ulrich ignores the sarcasm in her voice, steps forward, and rings the bell—

At that moment, the door swings open.

Research Assistant: ...?!

Hofmann: Huh?

An unexpected figure stands in the doorway.

Research Assistant: Good day, Madam Hofmann! I didn't expect you to be here.

Hofmann: The honor is mine, though I don't believe we've met?

Ulrich: Ms. Hofmann, long time no see. This is Dora, a research assistant in the cryptography team.

A hint of surprise colors Hofmann's face.

Hofmann: Ulrich, so your holiday is over.

Ulrich: Yes, I just returned to headquarters.

Hofmann: Were you looking for Adler?

Dora quickly takes over the conversation.

Research Assistant: Yes, the cryptography team hopes to enlist his help.

Hofmann gives a soft sigh, visibly weary.

Hofmann: I think ... now is not a good time to approach him. Adler is ... unwell.

Research Assistant: Understood.

In such a situation, no one would inquire about the specifics of his condition.

Ulrich: Ah, does he have a bacterial infection from being in a confined space for so long?

Hofmann: ...

Hofmann: It isn't a bacterial infection.

Dora takes a quick step forward, putting herself between Ulrich and Hofmann.

Research Assistant: Madam Hofmann! Is there anything we can do to help?

Hofmann: Of course, there is something I've been considering.

Hofmann: Adler's birthday is coming up.

Research Assistant: Birthday?

Hofmann: He's turning 28, but I'll be on a field mission to the Flannan Isles on the date.

Hofmann: I'd like someone to deliver a gift to him on my behalf on that day.

This seems like a good opportunity for Dora to break the ice with him.

Research Assistant: Absolutely, Madam Hofmann. Leave it to us!

Hofmann: It's appreciated. Thank you. I'll send the gift to you later.

Hofmann, satisfied with the arrangement, leaves at once.

Research Assistant: Looks like we've been handed a good opportunity.

Ulrich feels as though a rock has smashed through his tank.

He instinctively pats the glass, checking that it's still intact.

Ulrich: What exactly have you agreed to?

A Not-so-happy Birthday

COL-310709

A Not-so-happy Birthday

Adler's Office

The door creaks open, stirring up a small cloud of dust. Luckily, this visitor has no need to breathe.

The office's occupant hides behind a towering stack of papers, paying little attention to the intruder.

Ulrich: ...

Enigma: Visiting hours are over, and you don't have an appointment.

Enigma: Please, get out.

Ulrich: There's no such thing as "visiting hours" here.

Enigma: But I still have the right to control my private space.

Ulrich: Might I remind you that, fundamentally, an office is a semi-public space?

Ulrich: Treating it as private property is the result of primal, animalistic instincts and a serious violation of regulations.

Enigma: Theoretical physics research requires quiet, not people walking around and shouting at one another.

The sound of a scratching pencil comes from behind the papers, as if Enigma were finishing a crossword puzzle.

Ulrich: But you haven't submitted a single academic paper of value in seven years, nor made any other kind of contribution.

Ulrich: How long do you intend to indulge in this "humanitarian" management idleness?

Ulrich: You can't even keep the room clean!

Enigma: Oh, so you've returned from holiday as a sanitation inspector, have you?

Ulrich: I'm still the leader of the cryptography team. During my absence and since my return, the team has been running efficiently.

Ulrich: The number of internal complaints I've received has significantly decreased.

Enigma: You should give your work report to that tin can, not me. Now leave.

For the sake of his promise to Hofmann and his responsibilities as a leader, Ulrich resists the urge to walk out.

Ulrich: I had no desire to be here. But I gave my word to Ms. Hofmann.

Enigma: Her?

Research Assistant: I'm here!

Dora bursts into the room, two cardboard boxes in her arms.

She places the boxes on top of the already massive pile of paper.

Research Assistant: Sorry I'm late.

Enigma: Great, another one. Welcome. Make yourself at home.

Enigma: What's next, a full orchestra? A clown jumping out and serenading me?

Research Assistant: Well, not exactly—

Research Assistant: Happy 28th birthday, Mr. Adler!

Ulrich: ...

The sound of tearing paper fills the room as a crumpled calendar page is thrown over the stack of paper on the desk.

Enigma: Thanks for the reminder. I'd almost forgotten.

Research Assistant: ...

As her enthusiasm deflates, she gives a pleading look to Ulrich.

He responds with an annoyed shake of his head.

Research Assistant: Uh, Mr. Adler, I brought something for you.

Enigma: Yes, the boxes you so kindly already piled on my desk. One is signed by Greta Hofmann. Who's the other one for?

Research Assistant: For you, of course.

She quickly unwraps it for him.

Research Assistant: What ... what happened to it?!

Enigma: What is this?

Ulrich: It's the birthday cake Dora prepared. I assume you haven't so utterly detached yourself from society that you don't understand its significance.

Research Assistant: Ah!

She lets out a helpless scream.

Research Assistant: Who put so many candles on it?!

Enigma: Let's see—hah, 28. Genius.

Ulrich: It took a precise calculation to fit 28 candles perfectly on the cake, let me tell you.

Research Assistant: This is not happening!

Ulrich: There's no need to worry about your health, Dora. There's no evidence that ingesting paraffin and a small amount of dye causes any illness.

Enigma: Right, what we should be worrying about is carbon dioxide poisoning.

Research Assistant: No, that's not the problem! It's that ... Ugh!

Research Assistant: I can't even look at it!

She hurriedly recloses the cake box.

Research Assistant: Sorry, Mr. Adler. I'll get you a new one.

Enigma: No need. I'll eat this one.

Research Assistant: Then ... considering the fire hazard, let's skip lighting the candles.

Research Assistant: But we still have to sing the song. I even learned the German version.

Enigma: I understand English. By the way, when will your enthusiasm end?

Research Assistant: It's a magical song, don't you think? It sounds cheerful in any language.

She takes a deep breath.

Research Assistant: Happy birthday to you, happy birthday to you.

Research Assistant: Happy birthday, dear Adler!

Research Assistant: Happy birthday to you.

The final note hangs in the air before crashing to the ground like a solitary raindrop.

Ulrich: ...

Enigma: ...

Research Assistant: ...?

...

Silence.

...

All three of them, in total silence.

...

From the birth of the universe to the heat death of all things, there has not been and will never be a silence so profound.

...

Research Assistant: Was my German off?

Enigma glances at the cake on the paper pile, his expression resembling someone who has just swallowed a worm.

Enigma: Is anyone going to tell me what's going on here?

Enigma: Am I the one losing my mind here, or is it you two?

Enigma: This room is chaotic enough as it is. Leave, and don't come back!

The heavy atmosphere seems to have created an unresolvable standoff.

All attempts at social interaction have ended in dismal failure, like a well-intentioned ship crashing into an iceberg.

No one wants to blow out unlit birthday candles.

Research Assistant: This ... but ...

Ulrich: We've done all that we can. Let's go, Dora.

Ergodicity

COL-310710

Ergodicity

Cryptography Room, Laplace

Among the tedium of their daily work, the not-so-happy birthday party is gradually forgotten.

Research Assistant: The investigators' analysis reports on unknown incantations have been sorted.

Dora places a stack of paper forms on the desk and retrieves a floppy disk from her pocket.

Research Assistant: This disk contains known incantations similar to the ones the investigators reported. We can use it as a reference during our deciphering.

Ulrich: Very helpful indeed, Dora.

Ulrich takes the report from the top of the pile and gives it a quick look over.

Ulrich: These incantations seem rather common. I'll process the information as soon as possible.

Ulrich: As for the time needed to decode them ... I can't give an estimate, as always.

Research Assistant: We'll take it one step at a time.

Ulrich stands in his usual spot by the workbench, a steaming cup of coffee nearby.

The oscilloscope lies quietly in the corner of the room. Only the cryptography team knows that this device isn't part of the lab's computing systems.

After eight hours of hard work, Ulrich puts down the paper and hits the "Save" shortcut on the keyboard.

Ulrich: Let's call it a day.

Ulrich writes a few notes on a pad and sticks it on the base of the monitor—a long-standing end-of-day ritual.

Dora, who has been quietly waiting nearby, suddenly squats down as if responding to a signal.

Research Assistant: Impressive, Lead. You've clocked out on time for 47 consecutive days.

Ulrich: It's my duty to prioritize the health of my team members, and, of course, I need rest too.

He plugs the "brown noise channel" into his neck, and calming "music" designed for his kind reverberates inside the glass tank.

Rejuvenated, Ulrich glances at the oscilloscope in the corner of the room.

Ulrich: You can head out for the day. I'm going to reorganize the oscilloscope's historical data.

Research Assistant: It hasn't emitted any new signals since the last "Storm." You'll just be cycling through the same old data.

Ulrich: Maybe there's still something of value to be found, though, of course, I don't expect to find much.

Research Assistant: Do you need help?

Ulrich unplugs the music cable to ensure he heard her correctly.

Ulrich: You want to stay?

Research Assistant: Yes.

Ulrich: I've removed the work on oscilloscope cryptography from the team calendar. It's my personal problem now. No need to spend your time on it.

Research Assistant: Go on ahead. I'll stay a little longer.

Ulrich: You won't get any overtime pay.

Research Assistant: I know. But until you figure out what's going on with that little thing, you'll never be able to rest.

Research Assistant: For the sake of the whole team, let's just get this "personal problem" over with, shall we?

Oscilloscope: Beep-beep ...

[English text unavailable]

COL-310711

Cryptography Room, Laplace

Today's results, like those of the past few years, amount to nothing.

But both Ulrich and Dora have grown accustomed to the fruitlessness of this work.

Ulrich: Let's call it a day. Don't waste any more of our time.

Research Assistant: See you tomorrow, Lead.

Ulrich: Hmm ...

Dora packs up her belongings as she prepares to leave.

Ulrich pours the remainder of the coffee from the team's shared pot and drinks it, grit and all.

They each carry out their usual end-of-day routines, just like any ordinary day.

Dora opens the lab door to reveal an unexpected visitor.

Lucy: Very well. You are both here.

Clearly, today isn't an ordinary day. The alarms blare alongside the whining of machines.

Ulrich & Research Assistant: Madam Lucy?

Lucy: We are in an emergency situation. Foundation investigator Marcus has sent back information from Vienna about the leader of Manus Vindictae's immunity to the "Storm."

Lucy: The entire cryptography team is to focus on decoding the incantation. Effective immediately.

"Nebular Hypothesis"

COL-310712

"Nebular Hypothesis"

Office Square, Foundation

Foundation Staff Member I: Look at this. He's still here!

Ulrich: ...

Foundation Staff Member II: Oh, dear!

Clearly, Ulrich's ability to enact a hunger strike has been severely underestimated, even by his fellow strikers, who have all since given up.

Ulrich: Reinstate Madam Lucy! End her suspension!

He periodically voices his demands, only to be met with silence.

Foundation Staff Member I: ... Again!

Foundation Staff Member I: Is his head clamped between two neodymium magnets or something?

Foundation Staff Member II: Let's go.

They shoot Ulrich a brief, dismissive glance before hastily leaving.

Ulrich: Damn it!

Ten minutes have passed, with no new sympathizers joining Ulrich's cause.

In the bustling plaza outside the committee building, Ulrich has become the center of a circular no-man's-land of a few meters in radius.

Half an hour later, the morning rush subsides, and the square is left mostly empty.

Only a few latecomers, leisurely clutching their coffees, stroll by.

???: ...

A burst of hurried footsteps echoes through the square, getting louder and louder.

Ulrich: ...?

The steps seem to be coming straight for Ulrich.

Ulrich: No use trying to stop me. I won't be swayed by any appeasement tactics—

He turns, fully prepared for a showdown with the Foundation.

Enigma: Just get back in there!

Ulrich: Adler?!

Who could have expected this?

Ulrich: Don't you see, I'm—

Enigma: Yes, hunger striking. How very clever of you. Who else would possibly think of such a genius idea?

Enigma: What're you planning on doing? Waiting out here until the whole thing crumbles under its own weight?

Ulrich: I can't leave until I get some results. It would be an outright declaration of the LSCC's political defeat!

Enigma grits his teeth in frustration.

Enigma: Defeat? Madam Lucy is gone, and the LSCC is still struggling to find a suitable successor. How much more "defeated" could we be?

Enigma: The power plays are over. There's nothing left for the little people like us to do.

Enigma: Even if you stand here all year, you'll just become a statue like any other. No one in this great institution will even glance at you.

Enigma: Besides, I'm not handling all the piled-up paperwork for you.

Ulrich: That was never my responsibility to begin with.

Enigma: Great, then let entropy take over the LSCC. I'm sure it won't take long for the lab to spawn its own Big Bang.

Ulrich: My goal isn't to plunge the LSCC into chaos.

Enigma: Even doing the tiniest bit of actual work would make that statement more convincing.

Enigma: Like finally figuring out that oscilloscope that you still seem to know almost nothing about.

Ulrich: ...?!

Cryptography Room, Laplace

Ulrich: How do you know about the oscilloscope?

Enigma: It's not exactly inconspicuous.

Enigma: In a crucial place for decoding incantations, there's a machine that's utterly useless, and no one knows what it's for.

Enigma: Meanwhile, a magnetic tape beside it contains years of research notes on the thing.

Ulrich: You've read the research notes?

Before Ulrich can make a case for the invasion of his privacy, a new possibility catches his attention.

Enigma picks up a pristine notebook, already filled with letters and symbols.

Enigma: Not only did I read them, I added a few notes of my own.

Enigma: I have to say, some of your early hypotheses were laughable—"potential Awakened"?

Enigma: Heh.

Ulrich: That was simply raised out of courtesy. Clearly, such considerations are beneath you.

Ulrich snatches the notebook from Enigma's hands. Enigma gives no resistance.

Ulrich: ...

The writing on the pages is dizzying.

Ulrich: This isn't standard mathematical or logical notation. What exactly have you written here?

Enigma: I need better tools to sort out my cryptography process before this little notebook runs out of pages.

A glimmer of hope flickers through Ulrich's circuits.

Ulrich: Did you manage to crack those codes?

Enigma is well-prepared to deflect such heavy expectations.

Enigma: I'm not some kind of character who shows up at the end of the story to magically fix all the protagonist's problems.

Enigma: I only managed to uncover one issue.

He takes the notebook from Ulrich, flipping to a page marked with red annotations.

Enigma: After the sixth "Storm," the oscilloscope stopped generating new data. The final segment of information is unlike anything that came before it.

Enigma: I'm surprised how deaf you are to news outside the LSCC.

Enigma: Look here—1966. Almost simultaneously with the oscilloscope's signal cutoff, an LSCC satellite fell out of orbit.

Enigma: The fact that the two coincide suggests that this oscilloscope may be a receiver for a satellite signal.

Ulrich: I hadn't noticed that coincidence. But we can already rule out that possibility.

Ulrich: A receiver wouldn't have repeatedly received signals from the same satellite across multiple "Storms."

Ulrich: What about when the world was in eras before the invention of the satellite? Where did the oscilloscope's signals originate from then?

A silent smirk tugs at Enigma's lips.

Enigma: Haven't we only just found a way to survive the "Storm"?

[English text unavailable]

COL-310713

Cryptography Room, Laplace

Ulrich: ...

Enigma: ...

The very room itself seems to be holding its breath.

The two figures watch in silence, their silhouettes reflected on the main display among the numbers undergoing analysis.

beep

A crisp and exhilarating signal.

Ulrich: It's done.

The two of them lean closer to the monitor.

Ulrich: The number sequence translated by the new algorithm has passed the verification program.

Ulrich: From the first to the last character, every fragment aligns with an existing pattern.

Enigma: In simple terms, we've eliminated the garbled pieces of data from the original signal.

Ulrich: This sequence must be decipherable! If it's from a satellite, then ...

Ulrich: What could it be? What kind of data would a satellite transmit back to Earth?

Enigma bends over the keyboard, typing furiously.

Ulrich: Have you got an idea?

Enigma: It's not hard to guess. Satellite data would undoubtedly include images.

Ulrich: Why?

Enigma: Every space agency desperate for public funding tries to take pictures the moment their satellite gets into orbit.

Enigma: Because clueless bureaucrats and the media can only understand where the money went when they see a colorful picture.

Enigma: So this string of transmitted data must decode into an image.

Enigma hits the final "Enter" key with a dramatic flourish, accidentally triggering the room's light switch in the process.

Ulrich & Enigma: ...?

Enigma: We've done it.

The CRT monitor works tirelessly, painting a vibrantly oversaturated nebula across its screen.

Ulrich: I never would have expected this.

Even these two rational scholars can't help but marvel at the surreal brilliance of the image.

Ulrich: A photo from space, then there must be more.

Ulrich: Which nebula is that?

Enigma: No clue. Better to leave that to the astronomers.

Enigma: But here, see the time stamps?

Ulrich: 2004?!

Ulrich: So, then the satellite hasn't been affected by the "Storm."

Enigma: We only managed to produce the first Equilibrium Umbrella days ago! Who could have built this satellite?

Ulrich: Could it be that some engineer made it immune to the "Storm" entirely by accident?

Enigma: That's as unlikely as you starving to death.

Enigma: Or perhaps ...

Ulrich: Perhaps it was something onboard that protected it.

Ulrich: Something naturally immune to the "Storm," with no need for any input or modifications.

Ulrich: Something that would undoubtedly help us decipher the "Storm" itself!